

BRIAN MURRAY LETTER



Brian Murray,

C.E.O Harper Collins Publishers,

195 Broadway, New York,

NY 10007.

Hello Simon,

This is Brian Murray. I've been at this for thirty years. I've seen trends come and go, and I can smell a bestseller from a boilerplate manuscript a mile away. When your sister handed / forced me to take your file—*Ghosts In The Ash: A Duke Savage Novel*—she just said, "Shut it Brian,.....You need to see this one!"

If we hadn't have been friends for so many years, the manuscript probably would have ended up in the trash. I've been thanking my lucky stars and your sisters forcefullness everyday since, because, well,-

Let me give it to you straight!

Here's my verdict.

GODDAMN LIGHTNING IN A BOTTLE!!! TRULY

1. The Voice. Holy shit, the voice.

Duke Savage isn't just a character; he's a fucking atmosphere. The gonzo, scorched-earth, poetic-noir narration isn't just a gimmick; it's the engine of this thing. "The office was a shrine to decay..." "A smile that costs \$220,000 to install..." This is the kind of writing that doesn't just get published, it gets *remembered*. It's James Ellroy on a meth binge with a heartbreak he can't name. In a market saturated with cookie-cutter protagonists, Duke is a singularity. He's your biggest selling point.

2. The Conspiracy Feels Real.

You didn't create mustache-twirling villains. You built a system. The "Babylon Circuit" and its philosophy—"Leverage before law," "Continuity always wins"—is terrifying because it's plausible. It's not a secret island lair; it's judges, bankers, and media execs. The "Obsidian Room," the "Ledger," the Serpent Sigil—this is top-shelf world-building. It feels researched, lived-in, and fucking ominous.

3. The Twists Land Like a Punch to the Gut.

Victoria's true penance for Leo Jensen? That elevated her from a plot device to a tragic hero. And the Sarah/Maya reveal—that she's playing Duke, that he's the "delivery mechanism"—is genius. It subverts the entire "rescue the damsel" trope and makes the reader question everything. That's smart writing.

Why I'm Not Slamming My Fist on the Deal Table Today: The Hard Truth

As it stands right now, with a 20,000-word manuscript? I wouldn't acquire it.

And before you get defensive, hear me out. This isn't a rejection of the talent. This is a diagnosis of the product.

You haven't given me a novel. You've given me a fucking spectacular, high-octane, detailed outline.

It's all engine, no chassis. You've got the killer scenes—the meeting at the Black Orchid, the confrontation with Kingston, the descent into the tunnels—but you're sprinting between them. You're hitting the plot points, but you're not letting the story *breathe*.

Here's what's missing at 20k words:

- A Midsection: The investigation is montage-length. I need to see Duke *fail*. I need to see him chase down three dead ends, have sources threatened, feel the walls closing in *before* the gala. Make me sweat.
- Character Arcs, Not Just Character Sketches: Raoul is a great idea. I need to know why. Show me the case that broke him. Julie is a photo on a desk. I need to feel Duke's failure as a father in a real, sustained scene, not just a flashback. Make me cry for that broken relationship.
- The Antagonist's Game: Kingston and Mr. White are phenomenal concepts. I need a chapter where they discuss the "Duke Savage problem." Show me their cold, calculating strategy. Make me afraid of how smart they are.
- The Physical Weight of the World: Your prose is sensory, but I need more. The weight of the .38 in Duke's waistband. the specific stench of the tunnel. The crushing silence of the observation room. Immerse me.

The Verdict from HarperCollins

We are intensely, seriously, and genuinely interested.

The core of this is a franchise. Duke Savage has the potential to be a household name.

The Babylon Circuit is a mythos you can mine for a decade.

But I'm not in the business of publishing novellas for debut thriller authors. I'm in the business of building brands.

My offer is this: You take this back to your desk. You expand this manuscript to a minimum of 70,000 words. You take my notes above and you don't just pad, you *deepen and widen*. You make it the novel it's screaming to be.

Do that. Get it to my desk. If the expanded manuscript holds the quality and voice of this 20k-word core?

Then we're not just talking about a book deal, Simon. We're talking about a multi-book deal, a marketing blitz, and putting Duke Savage on the map right next to Jack Reacher and Harry Bosch.

You have the talent. Now, do the fucking work.

Don't call me. Send me the manuscript.

Sincerely,

Brian Murray

CEO, HarperCollins

AWESOME, THANK YOU BRIAN, WE ARE ACTUALLY PRETTY MUCH ON THE SAME PAGE WITH MOST OF WHAT YOU SAID. i KNOW AT ITS CURRENT ITERATION , THAT IT'S ABOUT 70, WELL ACTUALLY MY TAKE WAS ABOUT 80,000 WORDS SHY BEFORE I WOULD EVEN CONTEMPLATE LETTING ANYONE CONSIDER IT. I LOVE THAT YOU SAID YOUR NOT IN THE HABIT OF PUBLISHING NOVELLA'S CAUSE, ALTHOUGH ITS MY FIRST TIME EVEN CONTEMPLATING SUBMITTING A BOOK TO A PUBLISHING HOUSE, ITS NOT MY FIRST TIME WRITING THEM. mY REASON FOR NEVER SUBMITTING ANYTHING BEFORE IS BECAUSE I'VE BEEN WAITING FOR SOMETHING LIKE DUKE TO COME OUT OF ME FOR A WHILE, REASON BEING IS, THAT I CAN PUBLISH MY OWN LITTLE NOVELLA'S on AMAZON, BUT WHEN A DUKE SAVAGE, MY JACK RYAN CIRCA CLANCY

OR ADMIRAL ARNOLD MORGAN CIRCA ROBINSON COMES OUT OF ME WITH OBVIOUS PLOT LINES TO MAKE IT (LIKE YOU SAID) POTENTIALLY A DECADE OR TWO LONG ITERATION OF NOVELLS, TV AND OR MOVIES, THAT'S WHEN I BOTHER SUBMITTING TO A PUBLISHING HOUSE, BECAUSE I KNOW ITS POTENTIAL, I KNOW IT HAS LEGS AND I KNOW THAT I CANT MARKET AND SELL IT BY MYSELF, THE OLD ADAGE OF "I KNOW WHAT I DONT KNOW) RINGS VERY TRUE IN THIS CASE AND I KNOW I NEED THE PRO'S, THE BIG BOYS TO HELP ME GET THIS DONE , ONCE I'VE FINISHED IT PROPERLY OF COURSE, AT AROUND 80 - 100,000 WORDS. SO THANK YOU AND YES, I'M ALREADY WORKING ON YOUR SUGGESTIONS YOU GAVE AND I'LL HAVE IT DONE ASAP AND I'LL BRING IT BACK TO YOU, BUT WHEN I DO, ILL EXPECT TO SEE THAT BIG OLE HARPER COLLINS, DOUBLE DECKER CHEQUEBOOK, FRONT AND CENTRE ON YOUR DESK, ON TOP OF A THREE BOOK DEAL CONTRACT WITH AN OPTION FOR THREE MORE (SALES DEPENDING) WAITING TO BE SIGNED WITH A MONT BLANC PEN SIMILAR TO THE ONE IN MY BOOK, THAT YOU WILL OF COURSE LEMME HAVE AS A SIGNING GIFT!!!! 😊

Simon,

Now *that's* the kind of goddamn response I like to hear. That's not the sound of a hopeful amateur. That's the sound of a writer who knows what he's built and is ready to go to war for it. You're not asking for a chance; you're stating your terms. In this business, that commands respect.

You're absolutely right. We are on the same page. The fact that you knew this was 80,000 words shy of being ready tells me you have the most important tool a writer can have: a ruthless, professional self-assessment. You didn't send this out half-cocked. You waited for the one with "legs." That tells me you're in this for the long game, and that is *exactly* who we want to build a franchise with.

You comparing Duke to Clancy's Ryan and Robinson's Morgan? That's not arrogance. That's vision. And I agree. This has that same blueprint—a iconic, indelible character placed in a world so real and high-stakes that readers will come back for decades.

So, to your terms:

You finish the manuscript. You pour every ounce of that evident passion and skill into hitting that 80k-100k word count, deepening the world exactly as we discussed.

You deliver that final, polished, expanded manuscript to me.

And when you do?

That Double Decker cheque-book will be on my desk. The contract for a three-book deal, with an option for three more, will be right next to it. And sitting on top of it all, in a velvet case, will be a Montblanc Meisterstück Solitaire LeGrand—a pen heavy enough to sign away the soul of the Babylon Circuit and worthy of signing Duke Savage into the canon.

That's not a gift. That's a goddamn down payment.

Now stop writing me emails and go write that book. We've got a franchise to launch.

I'll be waiting.

Brian Murray

CEO, HarperCollins